

Low Tide

Original poem · Comprehension & poetic technique

Name: **Mayuka**Date: **9 August 2026**Time: **≈ 25 min**Marks: **___ / 21**

THE POEM

Stanza 1

*The sea drew back its heavy coat
reluctant, like a guest who stays
too long at someone else's door,
then leaves in slow, retreating waves.*

Stanza 2

*It left behind a hundred pools,
small worlds of glass held in the stone,
where anemones squat like clenched fists
and hermit crabs walk shells not their own.*

Stanza 3

*Salt-slick stones beneath bare feet,
a careful, curious, quiet creep —
each pool a held breath, a secret kept
from a tide that's only pretending to sleep.*

Stanza 4

*But the sea does not forget its coat.
Somewhere past the harbour wall
it is already turning back —
and every small world here will drown, and fall,
and none of it was ever truly mine to keep at all.*

QUICK-REFERENCE GLOSSARY — POETIC DEVICES

Personification:

giving human qualities to something non-human

Alliteration:

repeated consonant sound at the start of nearby words

Volta:

a turn or shift in tone, often near the end of a poem

Simile:

comparison using "like" or "as"

Enjambment:

a sentence running on past the end of a line, no pause

Rhyme scheme:

the pattern of end-rhymes, labelled with letters (ABCB, etc.)

QUESTIONS — ANSWER IN FULL SENTENCES

1 — Retrieval (1 MARK)

What has the tide left behind, according to Stanza 2?

2 — Structure: rhyme scheme (2 MARKS)

Identify the rhyme scheme of Stanza 1 (use letters, e.g. ABCB), and name one other stanza that follows the same pattern.

3 — Simile / imagery (3 MARKS)

Explain the effect of the simile "anemones squat like clenched fists" (Stanza 2). What does it suggest, and why is it an effective comparison?

4 — Sound devices (3 MARKS)

Identify one example of alliteration in Stanza 3 and explain the effect it creates for the reader.

5 — Personification (3 MARKS)

The sea is personified as "a guest who stays too long" in Stanza 1. Explain what this personification suggests about the tide, and how the poet's attitude to it develops by Stanza 4.

6 — Structure: the volta (4 MARKS)

How does the tone of the poem change in Stanza 4 compared to Stanzas 2 and 3? Refer closely to the language used in each.

7 — Extended response (5 MARKS)

How does the poet use language and structure across the whole poem to explore the idea that beautiful things can be temporary? Support your answer with at least three separate points, each backed by a quotation.

MODEL ANSWERS & MARK SCHEME

Q1 — RETRIEVAL (1 MARK)

- ✓ The tide left behind rock pools ("a hundred pools") containing small creatures such as anemones and hermit crabs.

Q2 — RHYME SCHEME (2 MARKS)

- ✓ **Point 1:** Stanza 1 follows an ABCB rhyme scheme (coat / stays / door / waves — only lines 2 and 4 rhyme).
- ✓ **Point 2:** Stanzas 2 and 3 follow the same ABCB pattern (pools/stone/fists/own; feet/creep/kept/sleep).

Q3 — SIMILE (3 MARKS)

- ✓ **Point:** the simile compares the anemones to "clenched fists," a tense, defensive image.
- ✓ **Evidence/Explain:** this suggests the anemones are tightly closed and guarded, which fits their real appearance when out of water — small and drawn in on themselves.
- ✓ **Effect:** it is effective because it turns a simple sea creature into something with a hint of emotion (defensiveness, vulnerability), preparing the reader for the poem's later idea that these small worlds are fragile.

Q4 — SOUND DEVICES (3 MARKS)

- ✓ **Identify:** "Salt-slick stones" (or "careful, curious, quiet creep") repeats a consonant sound at the start of nearby words.
- ✓ **Explain:** the repeated hard/soft sounds slow the line down and make it sound deliberate, almost like the sound of careful footsteps.
- ✓ **Effect:** this mirrors the cautious, quiet way the speaker is exploring the rock pools, drawing the reader into that same careful pace.

Q5 — PERSONIFICATION (3 MARKS)

- ✓ **Point 1:** comparing the sea to "a guest who stays too long" suggests the tide is unwelcome or overstaying, as if the rock pools' world resents its presence.
- ✓ **Point 2:** by Stanza 4, the tone shifts — the sea "does not forget its coat," suggesting inevitability rather than rudeness; it isn't a bad guest so much as something following a rule nothing can change.
- ✓ **Point 3:** this shows the poet's attitude softening from mild irritation at the tide's presence to a sadder acceptance that its return can't be stopped.

Q6 — THE VOLTA (4 MARKS)

- ✓ **Point 1:** Stanzas 2 and 3 use calm, hushed language ("a held breath, a secret kept"), creating a peaceful, intimate mood.
- ✓ **Point 2:** Stanza 4 opens with "But," a clear structural signal of a turn, immediately breaking that calm.
- ✓ **Point 3:** the language becomes more urgent and final — "drown, and fall" — in contrast to the gentle imagery before it.
- ✓ **Point 4:** the final line lengthens and slows with "and none of it was ever truly mine to keep at all," giving the ending a wistful, resigned tone very different from the quiet wonder of the middle stanzas.

Q7 — EXTENDED RESPONSE (5 MARKS, INDICATIVE CONTENT)

- ✓ **Point 1:** the rock pools are described as "small worlds" — the word "worlds" makes them sound complete and precious, which makes their coming destruction feel like more of a loss.
- ✓ **Point 2:** the personified tide is framed as something patient and certain ("it is already turning back"), contrasting with the fragile, temporary pools — structurally reinforcing that the powerful, permanent force will always outlast the delicate one.
- ✓ **Point 3:** the final line's shift to first person ("mine to keep") moves the poem from simply describing the pools to the speaker's own sense of loss, generalising the idea to anything beautiful a person cannot hold onto.
- ✓ (Full marks require three genuinely distinct points, each with its own quotation and explanation — reward any well-evidenced point in this spirit, not only these three.)